

Contractor vetting checklists, contract templates, payment protection frameworks, red flag guides — Action Checklist

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SCREEN BEFORE YOU MEET

- ☐ **Call Every Reference:** Call every reference your contractor provides and ask whether they would hire this person again, what went wrong, and whether the final cost matched the initial estimate because past clients reveal what the contractor won't volunteer about their real performance and billing practices.
- ☐ **Score the Conversation:** Score each contractor's answers to your phone screen questions on your scorecard immediately after hanging up, rating their directness and substance rather than their charm or confidence since problematic contractors deflect, get defensive, or give vague non-answers when pressed for real details.
- ☐ **Require a Contract First:** Require a signed contract that includes detailed scope of work, payment schedule, change order process, and dispute resolution before giving them any money, because verbal agreements are unenforceable and contractors who refuse written terms are planning to redefine the job later.
- ☐ **Limit Upfront Payment:** Never agree to pay more than 30% upfront and walk away from any contractor who demands a larger deposit, because heavy upfront payments transfer all the risk to you before a single tool is lifted and leave you with no leverage if things go wrong.

SCORE AND COMPARE

- ☐ **Fill Out Scorecards Same Day:** Complete your scorecard for each contractor on the same day as your meeting while your memory of their performance is still fresh, because emotional attachment grows with each passing day and documented impressions from hour one are far more reliable than later recollections.
 - ☐ **Score Independently First:** Score your contractor candidates independently before discussing with your partner or anyone else involved in the decision, because cross-contamination of opinions dilutes your data and you want separate evidence rather than confirming the same biases twice.
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- **Apply the 70% Minimum Threshold:** Reject any contractor scoring below 70% on your weighted scorecard and walk away from anyone below 60%, because a score below the minimum with promises to discuss details later means they'll tell you whatever you want to hear now and present a different story when invoicing arrives.
- **Compare Across Three Candidates:** Score all three contractors using identical categories and weights before making your decision, because scoring them against each other eliminates emotional attachment to any single quote and forces you to evaluate them on the same documented evidence base.

PROTECT YOUR MONEY

- **Check the Full Guide:** This step is described in detail in the companion guide — open contractor-proof-your-renovation.md and review the relevant section.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.